

# The 99-Cent Question

*At what point does "Bring Back the Castle" stop paying for itself?*

August 2026 · model at `mtc/model_99c.py` · every figure below is computed, not assumed

THE 99 CENTS IS A DONATION TO BRING BACK ALADDIN'S CASTLE. It is not an investment in \$ACM, is not solicited as one, and confers no expectation of profit. The token grant is a membership credential with no cash value inside the system. All wallet custody, token placement and revocation terms are disclosed in the ULA.

01

## The loop that closes on itself

A user pays 99¢. Apple takes its cut. From what is left we pay Solana account rent, a transfer fee, and grant the user some quantity of \$ACM as their membership credential. Everything remaining is profit, and **100% of profit buys more \$ACM** — which raises the price, which makes the next user's grant more expensive. The system funds its own cost inflation.

02

## Unit economics, per download

| Line                                | 15% tier (<\$1M) | 30% tier (>\$1M) |
|-------------------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| Price                               | \$0.9900         | \$0.9900         |
| Apple commission                    | -\$0.1485        | -\$0.2970        |
| Solana account rent (sunk)          | -\$0.4080        | -\$0.4080        |
| Transfer fee                        | -\$0.0010        | -\$0.0010        |
| <b>HEADROOM available for \$ACM</b> | <b>\$0.4325</b>  | <b>\$0.2840</b>  |

Rent is modelled as **non-recoverable**. It is refundable only by closing the account, which means shutting the system down — and a user who changes phones leaves a wallet we cannot reclaim. For a going concern it is a cash outlay, and **every download is a new wallet** even when it is the same human on a second device.

03

## The master equation

break-even \$ACM price = headroom ÷ grant per user  $\$0.4325 \div 1 \text{ token} = \$0.4325$  works until price rises  $1,632 \times \$0.4325 \div 1,000 = \$0.00043$  works until price rises  $1.6 \times \$0.4325 \div 10,000 = \$0.00004$   
 ALREADY UNDERWATER TODAY

At today's price of \$0.000265 the largest grant that breaks even is **1,632 \$ACM** at the 15% tier, or **1,071** at 30%.

KRW-C-2026-002's cooling machine needs roughly 10,000 \$ACM per user to move float meaningfully. The 99¢ app can fund 1,632. It pays for 16% of what cooling requires.

04

## The answer

# 10,000,000 downloads

Every one of them profitable, at **\$0.4325** per download below the \$1M Apple threshold and **\$0.2840** above it. Total banked over the pool's life: **\$2.84M – \$4.33M**. The wall arrives not from weak demand but from the pool running dry.

Your wallet holds **11,767,037 ACM**. Releasing **10,000,000** as the funding pool and holding **1,767,037** as R&D reserve gives ten million downloads of free inventory at one token per user — every grant costs nothing, and the margin is the full headroom.

Sensitivity only — the design grants **one** token. The rows below show why that is the right call, not an open question:

| Grant per user     | Downloads covered free | Then               |
|--------------------|------------------------|--------------------|
| 1 ACM ← THE DESIGN | 10,000,000             | must buy at market |
| 10 ACM             | 1,000,000              | must buy at market |
| 100 ACM            | 100,000                | must buy at market |
| 1,000 ACM          | 10,000                 | must buy at market |

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## What stops it — and it is us

Because 100% of profit buys \$ACM, by the time the pool empties at ten million downloads that buying has lifted the price from \$0.000265 to **\$18.62** — a factor of **70,266**. The next token then costs \$18.62 against \$0.2840 of headroom.

**Buying \$ACM with the profits is what prices the program out of its own token. The app makes the asset valuable and is then unable to afford the thing it made valuable.**

| Redeployment policy     | Price at pool-out | Can the program continue?      |
|-------------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------|
| Redeploy 100% (planned) | \$18.62           | No — one token costs \$18.62   |
| Redeploy 0% (hold cash) | \$0.000265        | Yes — one token costs \$0.0003 |

The R&D reserve is the other side of that coin: **1,767,037 ACM at \$18.62 is \$32.9M** on paper. That is a real number and an unsellable one — a \$22.7K pool cannot be exited at anything near that price, because the same  $(1 + C/R)^2$  curve runs in reverse on the way out.

06

## The two levers still open

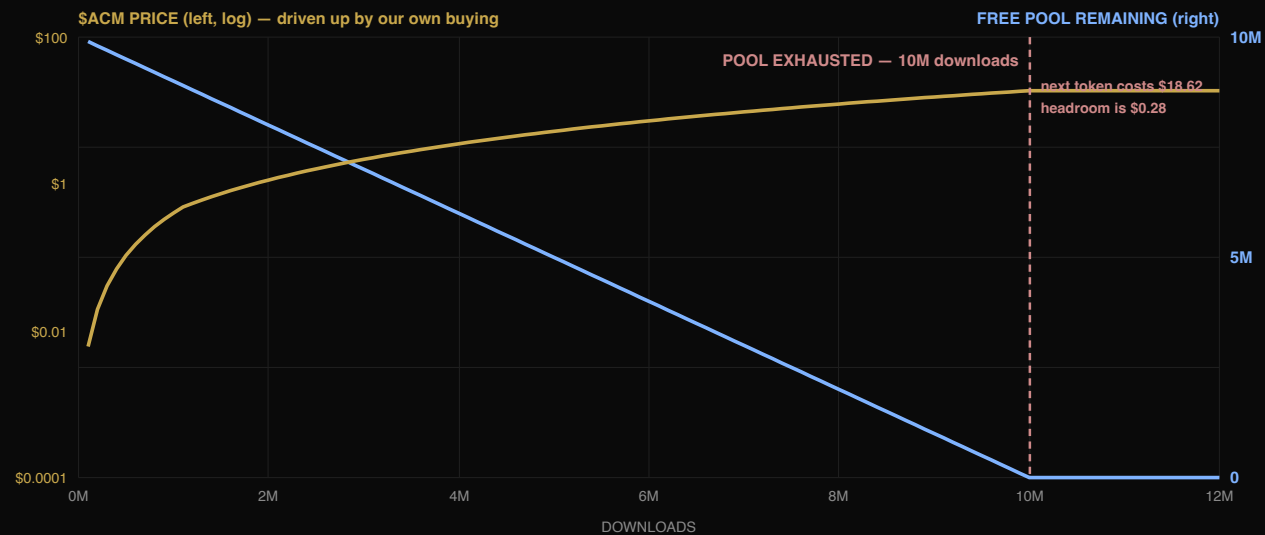
The grant size is settled at one token — that decision is already what buys the ten million downloads. These two are not yet settled:

| Lever                             | Effect                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Redeploy less than 100% of profit | The single decision that determines whether the program survives past ten million downloads. At 100% the token reaches \$18.62 and the program cannot afford it. At 0% it stays at \$0.000265 and simply continues. |
| Deepen the pool before launch     | ~\$100,000 of quote-side depth absorbs the redeployed buying rather than repricing on it, which softens the wall without giving up the redeployment.                                                                |

And one that is not a lever: **rent consumes 41% of gross at every scale**. It is fixed in dollars, it is the largest cost after Apple, and it does not come back. Not minting a wallet until a user actually engages would recover more than any other change on this page.

Why the system chokes on its own success

Blue: the free pool draining, one token per download. Gold: the \$ACM price, driven up by our own redeployed profit. The program is comfortably profitable for the whole blue line — then hits a wall the gold line built.



Both axes logarithmic. Model: 1 \$ACM granted per user, 100% of profit redeployed, constant-product price impact  $P'/P = (1 + C/R)^2$  per KRW-C-2026-001, quote reserve seeded at \$11,373.

READING IT

| Downloads  | Free pool left | \$ACM price | State                                    |
|------------|----------------|-------------|------------------------------------------|
| 1,000,000  | 9,000,000      | \$0.40      | profitable · grant free                  |
| 3,000,000  | 7,000,000      | \$2.05      | profitable · grant free                  |
| 6,000,000  | 4,000,000      | \$7.16      | profitable · grant free                  |
| 9,000,000  | 1,000,000      | \$15.32     | profitable · grant free                  |
| 10,000,000 | 0              | \$18.62     | POOL GONE — next token \$18.62 vs \$0.28 |

Ten million paid downloads is an extraordinary outcome for a nostalgia app. The model says you would reach it profitably — and that the thing which finally stops you is a policy choice you control, not the market.

Read the other direction, this is a **constructive** result. Instagram drew 762 million downloads globally in 2025; ten million is a little over one percent of that, and every one of those ten million pays for itself. The binding constraint is not demand and not Apple — it is how much \$ACM leaves the pool per user, and what the profit does next. Both are yours to set.